had appointed Subrahmanyam to head a task force to examine the different aspects of global trends in strategic affairs in November 2005. A towering, Kissinger-like figure, Subrahmanyam could build consensus within India's policy community on strategic issues. Within six months, the task force came up with a classified document on how India should conduct diplomacy after 9/11.[133] Mostly an exercise in internal propaganda, the paper advocated deeper engagement with the various emerging power poles across the world and underlined the benefits of aligning with the US.[134] With George W. Bush, a heavily pro-Indian president in the White House, convincing the Indian bureaucracy to reduce its mistrust for the US was not a daunting task. Narayanan, who became NSA in 2005, explains this change in Indian thinking as such:

> From an Indian standpoint we felt that he [Bush] certainly was an unusual American and that he would not do anything that would hurt Indian interests ... my assessment is that change in our attitudes even in Afghanistan started with the advent of the Bush era ... the principle issue is that Bush in the White House made it easier for India to be accepted in various American quarters ... I think there was a fundamental shift in the US about India [as] they really wanted us to emerge [and] never asked us whether you want to fight terrorism. Countering China may have been a long term [US goal] but they didn't articulate it as such ... I would take Bush at his word.[135]

Slowly, but surely, the impact of Subrahmanyam, Narayanan, the larger Indian political leadership (both the Congress and the BJP) and Bush's outreach began to make an impact. India began cooperating with Washington in an unhindered fashion on most strategic issues and the bilateral relationship bloomed in the wake of the India-US nuclear deal.

Bonn compromise

Not just in the military domain, India was further marginalised by Afghanistan's post-Taliban political formation processes as well. India was, for instance, not invited to the critical Bonn Conference that occurred between 27 November and 5 December 2001.[136] Lakhdar Brahimi, the UN's special envoy to Afghanistan, who chaired the conference, had decided to not offer India a place in the guesthouse Petersberg that was meant only for delegates from the six plus two and the P-5 countries, (but not for the G-21, which India was a part of).[137] Even when India did join as an observer, along with sixteen other countries, it